to the very principles of the Communist system. The liberal intellectuals who led the political changes in most of Eastern Europe were often out of touch with the conservative masses and they needed the Church and conservative intellectuals to motivate people and bring them to the polling stations. Still, over the years, association with the Churches became a liability, as they could no longer be of assistance in facing the increasingly post-liberal and post-modern society. The Churches themselves began to be overwhelmed by the unexpected and fast-advancing landslide of secularisation, and torn over the question of how to follow their missions in these new social circumstances, not least from a purely material point of view. The freedom suddenly seemed more of a challenge than an opportunity.

In any event, it would be rather superficial to portray the democratic changes in Central Europe in black and white terms, and to reduce it to a struggle between Communists and non-Communists. After all, individuals in Eastern Europe have reacted to the changes of transition in many different ways, reflecting their different places in society, as well as personal and family backgrounds. There are those who have never really trusted the new political parties and the changes that they have brought, and who remember the good old days with nostalgia, either because of the perks they used to enjoy or because their lives did not really change for the better (sometimes they became more difficult). This has given rise to support for various radical, extreme left and/or chauvinist parties, or for one of the reincarnations of the former Communist party. In the conservative camp, there are people who, whatever their present economic situations, continue to be staunch supporters of the new political parties, often with a strong anti-Communist rhetoric. Curiously, at the time of the changes in the early 1990s, these were usually also the strongest supporters of membership of the European Union, which they saw as a powerful weapon against the former Communist elites. Unfortunately, some of these enthusiasts have in the recent decade moved to occupy radical Eurosceptic or even xenophobic positions. And it is Euroscepticism and xenophobia where extreme left and extreme right movements often meet.

Then there are the nouveaux riches, sometimes with strong connections with ex-Communists who have reinvented themselves as liberals. The creation of this new social class was only possible where a strong urban